> yours is mine . . . the same sort of arrogance India demonstrates repeatedly towards its other neighbours . . . The Indian leaders were students and heirs of British imperialists . . .[97]

The Singapore diplomat Kishore Mahbubani was told by a senior Chinese official, who was personally involved in Sino-Indian negotiations, that there was always a standard conversation between the Chinese and Indian sides in the border negotiations. The Indian side would begin the negotiations by observing that senior Chinese leaders, including Zhou and Deng Xiaoping, had proposed on at least three occasions that both sides reach a final settlement of the border issue based on the existing line of control with no major adjustments in territory. The Indian side then would ask, 'Why doesn't China table this proposal again?' The Chinese official said that the response to this question would be, 'Why didn't you accept it when China proposed it?' and that's where the conversation would end.[98]

In 2020, a more recent perspective emerged on why a border settlement, and indeed a larger rapprochement, appears so remote. Sun Yun, Senior Fellow of the Stimson Center in Washington, DC, a perceptive China scholar, suggested that Beijing is unwilling to accommodate Delhi, including on the border, in the belief that Delhi will not make meaningful reciprocal concessions: 'For China, key concessions such as the border settlement are irreversible hard commitments, while all that India can deliver in return, such as its neutrality between China and the US, is ephemeral and can be easily reversed.'[99] If China truly holds to this position, then virtually any border settlement and larger diplomatic accommodation becomes untenable.

The second phase of border negotiations, 1989–2005

Almost coincident with the petering out of the border negotiations was the military confrontation in June 1986 between the two militaries at Sumdorong Chu in Arunachal Pradesh. India accused China of coming south of the mountain slopes in the state. China insisted that its forces were north of the line. Both sides quickly amassed large forces, and hostilities